These developments hadn’t gone unnoticed in Pakistan, where the military was back in power, after dismissing Bhutto in 1977.

Coinciding with the dismissal of Zulfikar Bhutto was the 1977 state assembly elections. It was regarded as a referendum of Abdullah’s accord with Indira Gandhi in 1975. The 1987 elections turned out to be quite the opposite of that: allegations of mass malpractice against the Farooq Abdullah-led National Conference spread across the valley, even though an objective civil servant—the highly regarded Wajahat Habibullah—found them to be true in only 10 constituencies, mostly in Srinagar. Jagmohan later denounced the entire elections as rigged. There was open rigging in the Amira Kadal constituency, where Ghulam Moinuddin Shah, a close relative of Farooq, was pitted against Syed Mohammed Yusuf Shah of the MUF. They had allegedly replaced the ballot boxes and this, as Habibullah concedes, was a turning point after which the Kashmiri people had decided that they had had enough. When the Kashmiris, fed up with the manipulations of politicians in Srinagar and Delhi, raised a cry for independence following the rigged elections of 1987, it gave Pakistan the opportunity it was looking for. Many of those who were polling agents for Syed Mohammed Yusuf Shah were imprisoned without bail for months and subjected to harsh treatment. But when freed, these young men went on to become militant leaders of the insurgency that hit Kashmir in 1989. Shah went off to Pakistan to head the Hizb-ul-Mujahideen under the adopted name of Syed Salahuddin. In fact, Pakistan had begun to flood the valley with weapons, ammunition and trained militants just after the 1987 elections.

Even though New Delhi had continued to insist that the Shimla Agreement had resolved all areas of Indo-Pak disputes, including the Kashmir issue, the Pakistan Army, especially after the Soviet withdrawal from Afghanistan, became obsessed with ‘doing a Bangladesh on India’ in Kashmir. This coincided with a similar movement in eastern Europe as the Soviet Union broke up. And so, Pakistan initiated a well-planned operation to liberate the valley from India after a large number of Kashmiri youths, appalled with the 1987 elections, crossed the LoC, which was then an